



Incentivizing the Move to Bluesky Through Accessibility

A UX case study on communicating value, restoring user control, and designing for visual accessibility in a decentralized social platform.

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ROLE
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FORMAT
Simulated design sprint, one
week (2024)

TOOLS
Figma, FigJam,
Qualtrics

ABSTRACT

Bluesky arrived with real momentum as a decentralized alternative to Twitter/X, yet it has struggled to hold on to the people who try it. This project asks why. Drawing on public user commentary gathered across Reddit, Twitter/X, and Bluesky itself, I identified three recurring sources of friction: the app fails to communicate what makes its AT Protocol different, it withholds basic controls that users expect from a platform built on autonomy, and its accessibility support for visually impaired users trails behind competitors. Working mobile-first and within a one-week sprint, I moved from secondary research through personas, a journey map, and a competitive accessibility audit, then designed three targeted interventions: an AT Protocol onboarding flow with inline tooltips and a media grid view; algorithmic feed filters keyed to text, visual keywords, and topics; and editable alt text paired with continuous contrast and type-size sliders. Paper wireframes were tested with six participants before high-fidelity prototypes were built in Figma and re-evaluated with the same group. The essay closes with two reflections on restraint in feature design and on why the status quo of accessibility on major platforms should not be treated as the ceiling.

1. Overview

This is an independent, self-directed project. I am not affiliated with Bluesky; the platform was chosen because it sits at an unusual intersection of strong ideological appeal and weak practical adoption, which makes it a rich subject for UX research. Everything that follows is the work of one person over one week, and I have tried to be honest about what that constraint allowed and what it did not.

PROBLEM

Bluesky struggles with user acquisition and retention, partly because its UX obscures its own core value

Despite early buzz as a decentralized alternative to Twitter/X, Bluesky has had a hard time turning curiosity into habit. Forums are full of people who signed up, looked around, and drifted back. The criticisms cluster in a consistent way: the app never explains the benefits of its decentralized model, it offers limited customization, and its accessibility lags behind both Twitter/X and Threads. Taken together, these complaints point to a clear need for a more inclusive, user-centered design that meets modern usability standards and, just as importantly, makes the platform's reason for existing legible to a first-time user.

SOLUTION

Introduce the architecture, expand control, and widen access

To encourage adoption, I designed and integrated a set of tools that introduce new users to Bluesky's architecture, hand them more control over what they see, and extend accessibility for visually impaired users. The redesign adds a short onboarding carousel and inline tooltips that explain the AT Protocol in plain language, a media grid view that gives the timeline a distinct visual identity, filters for tailoring the feed, and a pair of accessibility features: editable alt text and slider-based contrast and font-size controls. Each of these is tied directly to something users asked for.

I organized the work around three qualities I wanted the product to embody.

Transparent. A brief onboarding and inline tooltips highlight Bluesky's decentralized architecture, so that users understand what makes the platform unique and how it protects their digital autonomy.

Customizable. Bluesky already lets people build their own content-sorting algorithm as they use the app. With new filters based on text and visual keywords, users can fine-tune their feeds further to match their preferences.

Accessible. Users with greater accessibility needs are a vital part of both Bluesky's current and potential community. Adaptable tools like editable alt text and customizable sliders for contrast and type size are a way of saying, concretely, that these users are valued and included.

2. Research

PRELIMINARY RESEARCH

Identifying UI and accessibility gaps from user commentary across digital platforms

I started by exploring Bluesky's UX challenges as users themselves describe them. With no access to the company's analytics or support logs, public commentary was the richest source available, and in some ways the most candid: people writing on Reddit or in Bluesky's own feedback threads are not answering a survey, they are venting.

That candor cuts both ways, so I was careful about method. To avoid self-serving bias, I gathered findings from multiple independent sources rather than a single community, so the picture would not be skewed toward one viewpoint or demographic. I also kept my search queries neutral, avoiding phrasing that could introduce confirmation bias or reflect judgments I had already formed. The goal was to let the pattern emerge rather than go looking for the one I expected.

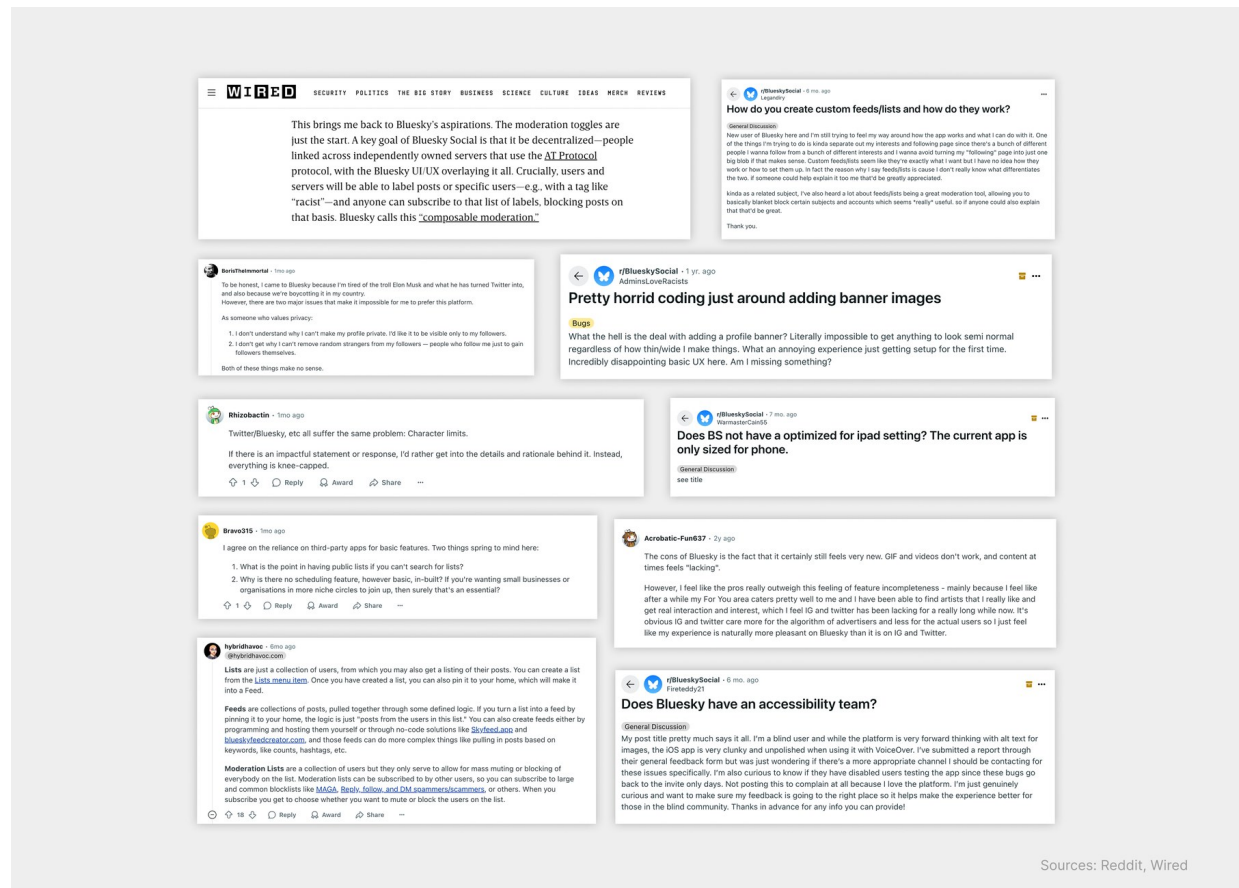


Figure 1. A sample of the user commentary collected during secondary research, with recurring themes annotated.

The truth is that a lot of people are leaving Twitter/X and Meta-owned platforms over centralized data handling and what many of them call digital tyranny. Perfect, then: Bluesky must be capitalizing on its own architecture to draw in the crowds? Not exactly. The single most frequent complaint I found was Bluesky's inability to convey its own value, that is, to tell users what the decentralized AT Protocol is and why it matters. According to users, neither the app nor the website clearly communicates that Bluesky is, by design, a platform built for digital freedom. Worse, its current design system unintentionally echoes the aesthetic of Twitter/X, which makes the difference even harder to see.

Beyond that, user posts surfaced a handful of practical pain points: missing basics like list filtering and post scheduling, poor tablet optimization, and incompatibility with screen readers.

In the end, three issues stood out as the most significant sources of UX friction, as reported by users.

1. Users are seeing Twitter/X in another font.

Why switch to a copycat of the more popular platform? People who move see the same layout and the same colors, and they are not clearly told about the AT Protocol or its benefits. The result is that Bluesky is hard to distinguish from the thing it is supposed to replace.

2. The platform lacks important key features.

For a company that champions user freedom, Bluesky falls short on basic features that would improve usability and accessibility alike. From tablet layouts to the inability to schedule or edit posts, it overlooks fundamental needs.

3. Accessibility support is lacking, particularly for people with visual impairments.

Bluesky lacks built-in alt text display, which forces impaired users to rely on third-party tools for image and video posts. Its three font-size options are only marginally different from one another, leaving those who need higher contrast or larger type without a usable setting.

EMPATHIZING

Understanding our users, and the importance of accessibility, through a persona and a journey map

It is no surprise that most social platforms offer extensive accessibility features and support third-party screen readers, given the size and diversity of their user bases. To keep that stake in view while designing, I created a Bluesky persona, Mark, to visualize what daily life on the platform might look like for a user with a visual disability.

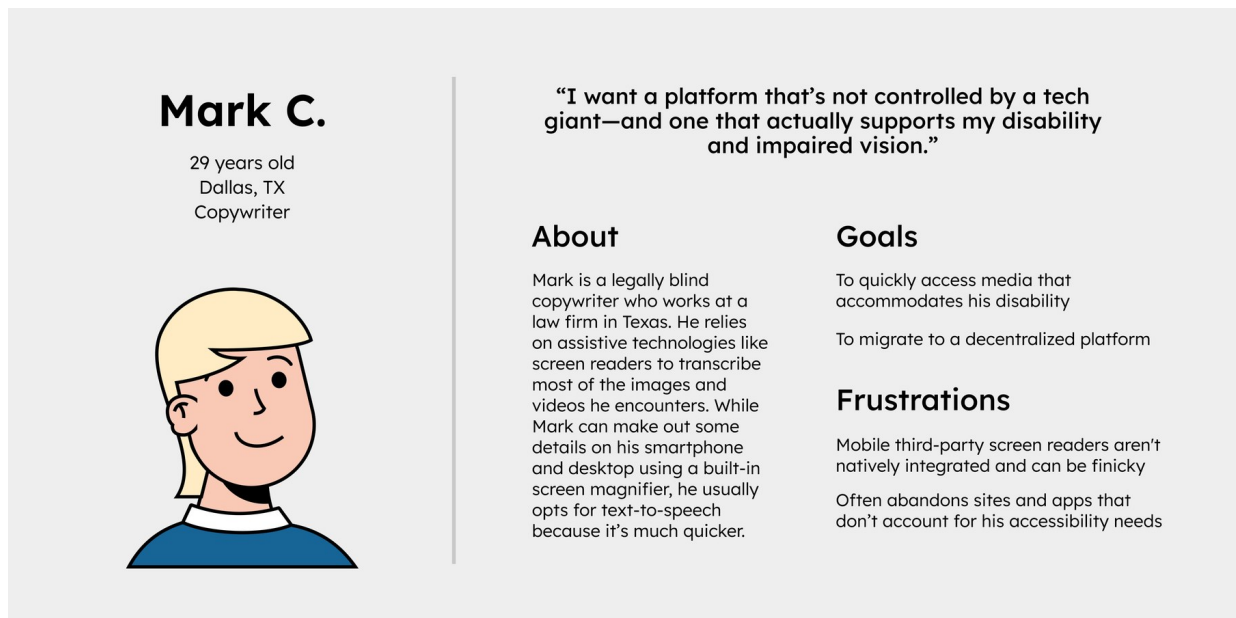


Figure 2. Persona. Mark relies on a screen magnifier and built-in text-to-speech; his frustrations center on unreliable screen-reader support and apps that ignore his needs.

The research suggests that Bluesky is mostly accessible, but its alt text handling and its font and contrast settings still need work to serve someone like Mark well. To push the empathy further, I built a journey map illustrating how a user with a visual impairment might interact with Bluesky over time, from first hearing about it through posting. One thing worth stating plainly: accessibility is not binary. It exists on a spectrum, which means users have different journeys based on their individual needs, and a single persona can only ever stand in for one point on it.

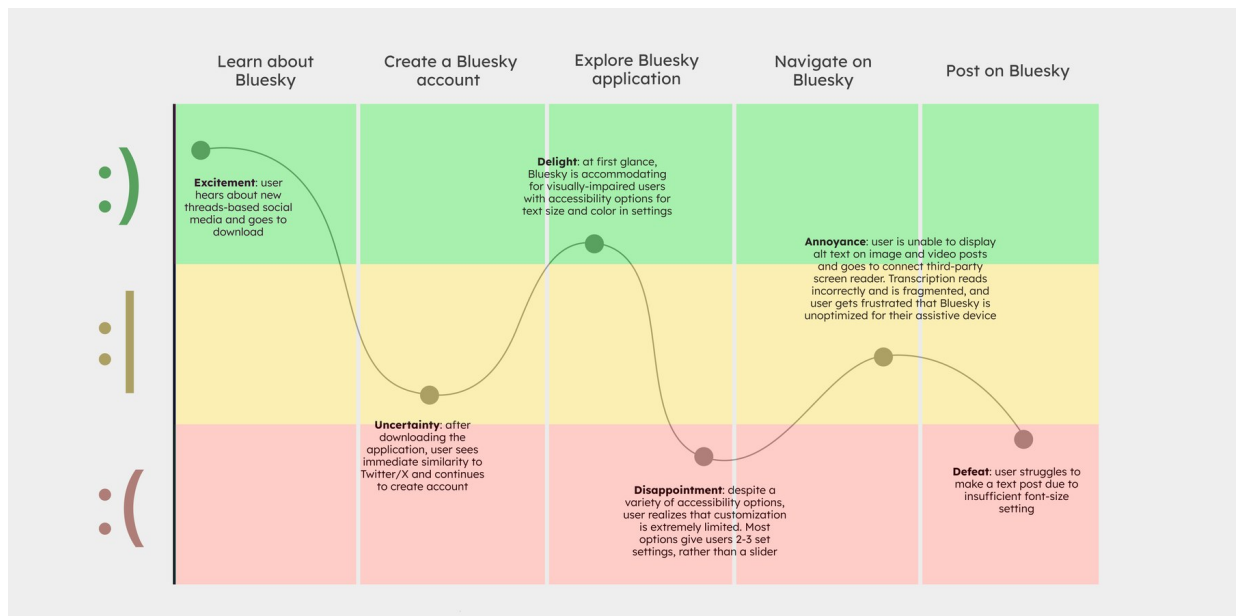


Figure 3. Journey map for a visually impaired user, tracking emotional highs and lows from discovery to first post.

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Examining how other platforms support and enhance accessibility for visually impaired users

To support an accessible migration to Bluesky, I looked at how major platforms, Meta's in particular, design inclusive scrolling interfaces and lean on accessibility-focused extensions.

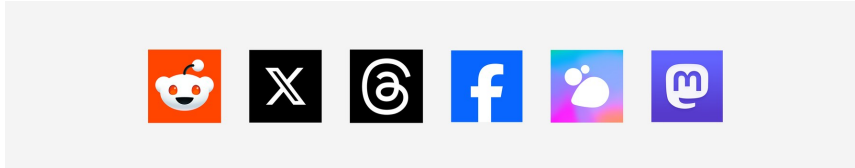


Figure 4. Platforms and extensions reviewed: Reddit, Twitter/X, Threads, Facebook, Bluesky, and Mastodon.

The context matters here. Desktop browsers support a wide range of visually assistive extensions such as ChromeVox, Read Aloud, and Helperbird. Mobile devices with app-based operating systems handle accessibility differently: users typically cannot install extensions, so mobile versions of Threads and Twitter/X ship their own in-app accessibility options. Since most Bluesky users are on their phones, this is the standard Bluesky has to meet.

My review of accessibility practice across competing platforms led to five working insights that carried through the rest of the project.

1. *Automated alt text generation makes more content accessible.*
2. *Visual customization works better with sliders than with a small set of fixed options.*
3. *Editable captions and alt text keep content accessible when mistakes or omissions happen.*
4. *Applications should honor system-level settings that reduce motion and animation.*
5. *High-contrast theme options improve readability for everyone, not just users with impairments.*

3. Ideation

BRAINSTORMING

Exploring UI and accessibility-improving features, one friction at a time

I took the three frictions from research in order and gave each its own ideation pass, partly for discipline and partly because they call for different kinds of thinking.

To address the first issue, Bluesky's resemblance to Twitter/X, I sketched a two-part initiative: first, elevating the AT Protocol to a visible value proposition instead of a footnote; and second, adjusting visual and interaction design elements so that users perceive Bluesky as its own thing rather than a re-skin.

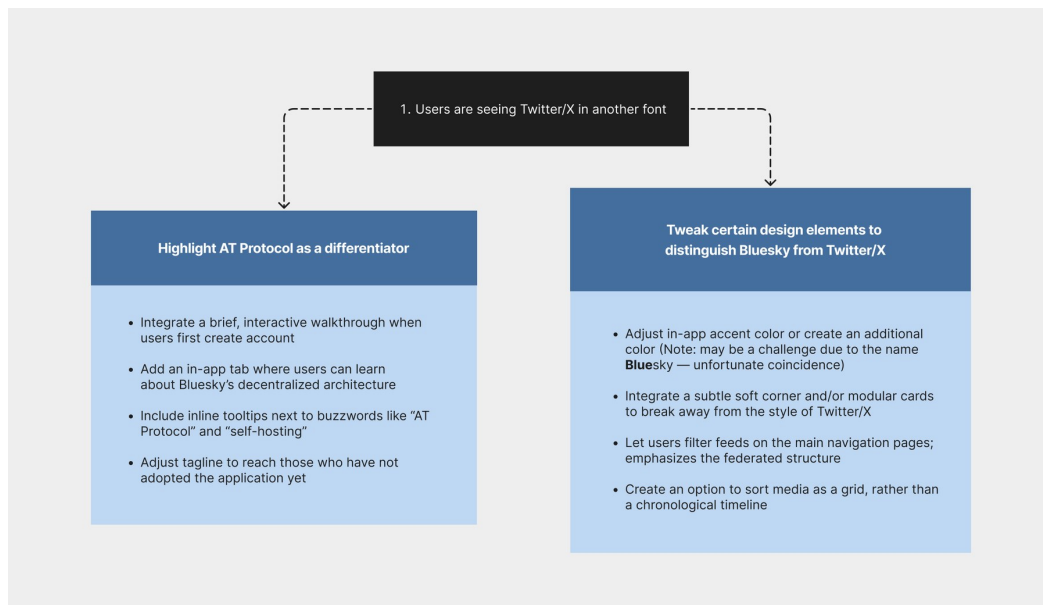


Figure 5. Two-part plan for differentiating Bluesky from Twitter/X: surface the AT Protocol, then adjust visual and interaction design.

For the second issue, the absence of key social-media features, I built a FigJam sticky-note dashboard to lay out a wide range of candidate features and began grouping those that aligned best with the platform's goals and with what users had asked for. I gave priority to features that are both essential according to users online and uniquely enabled by Bluesky's architecture, meaning things competitors could not easily copy.

Staying focused mattered here. It is easy to solve "missing features" by adding all of them, and the research was unambiguous that too many unnecessary features lead to feature fatigue and overwhelm the very users you are trying to keep.

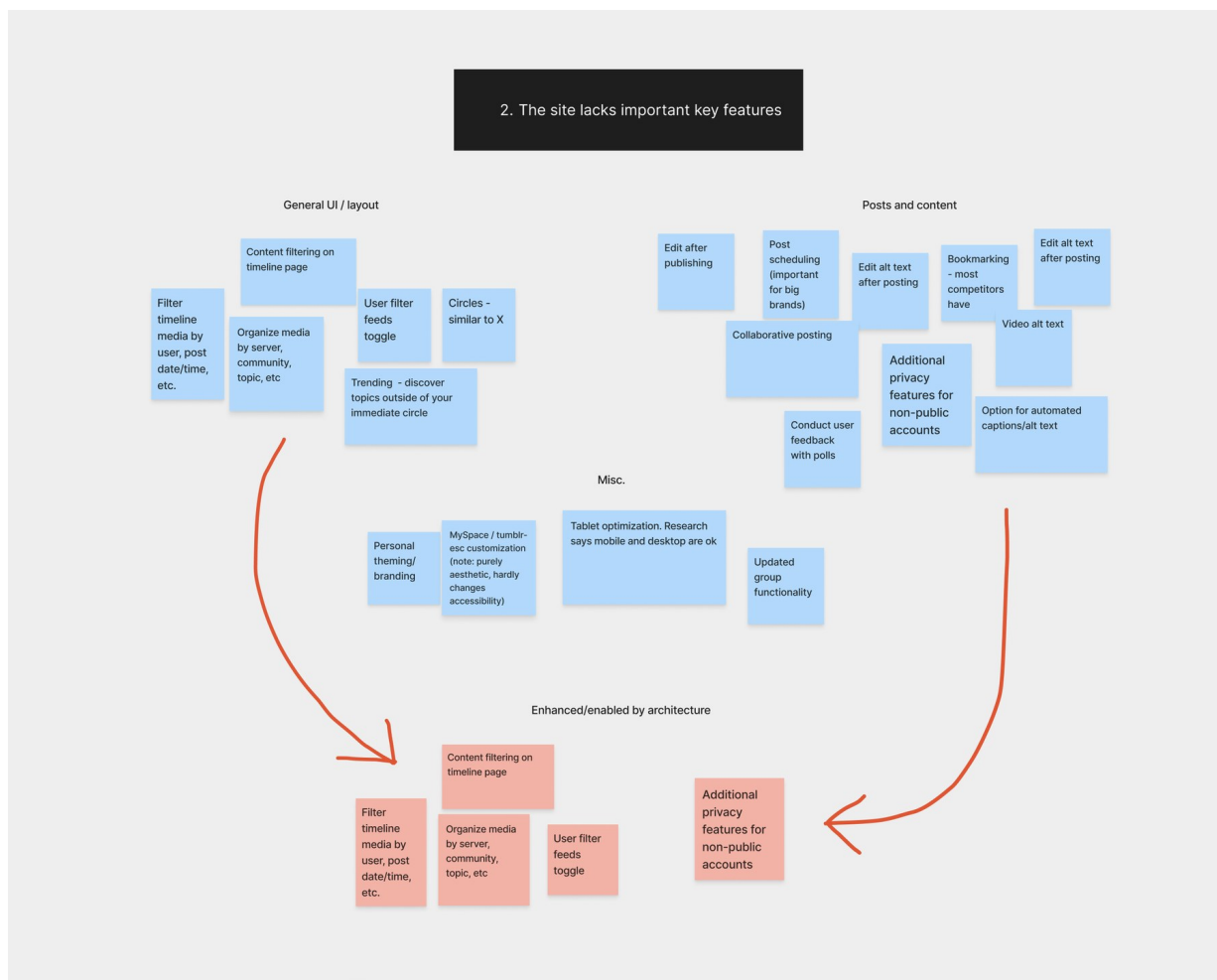


Figure 6. FigJam feature dashboard, with candidate features grouped and narrowed toward those users called essential.

For the third issue, insufficient accessibility support, I ran a competitive feature audit and organized the results in Figma, using the five accessibility insights as the rows. The chart made it easy to see where competing platforms excel, where they fall short, and therefore where Bluesky has an opportunity not just to catch up but to lead.

	 Reddit	 Twitter/X	 Threads	 Facebook	 Hive Social	 Mastodon	 Bluesky
Alt text for images	✓ Manual	✓ Manual and prompted	✓ Manual	✓ Manual and prompted	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Manual	✓ Manual
Alt text editing	✗ Not currently supported	✗ Not currently supported	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Supported	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Supported	✗ Not currently supported
Text rescaling	✓ OS-supported	✓ OS-supported	⚠ Limited support	✓ OS-supported	✗ Fixed sizes	✓ OS-supported	⚠ Selection of 3 fixed sizes
Screen reader compatibility	✓ Strong compatibility	✓ Strong compatibility	⚠ Moderate compatibility	✓ Strong compatibility	⚠ Limited compatibility	⚠ Moderate compatibility	⚠ Moderate compatibility
Automated video captions/caption support	✓ Manual	✓ Manual and auto CC	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Manual and auto CC	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Manual	✗ Not currently supported
Accessible labels on UI elements	✓ Supported	✓ Supported	⚠ Inconsistent	✓ Supported	✗ Incomplete	✓ Supported	⚠ Inconsistent
Keyboard navigation support	✓ Supported	✓ Supported	✗ Incomplete	✓ Supported	✗ Incomplete	✓ Supported	⚠ Limited support
High contrast mode	⚠ OS-dependent	✓ Supported	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Supported	✗ Not currently supported	✗ Not currently supported	✓ Supported

Figure 7. Competitive accessibility audit across six platforms.

Expanding accessibility is essential for a company like Bluesky, whose whole pitch is user privacy and autonomy. But some features are considerably harder to build than others, and it would be irresponsible to pretend otherwise. Automating text captions for video, for instance, likely requires external services such as speech-to-text APIs or server-side processing, whereas text rescaling can usually be handled entirely within the app's front end. I weighed feasibility alongside user demand when choosing what to carry into design.

After weighing all of this, I committed to the following core features.

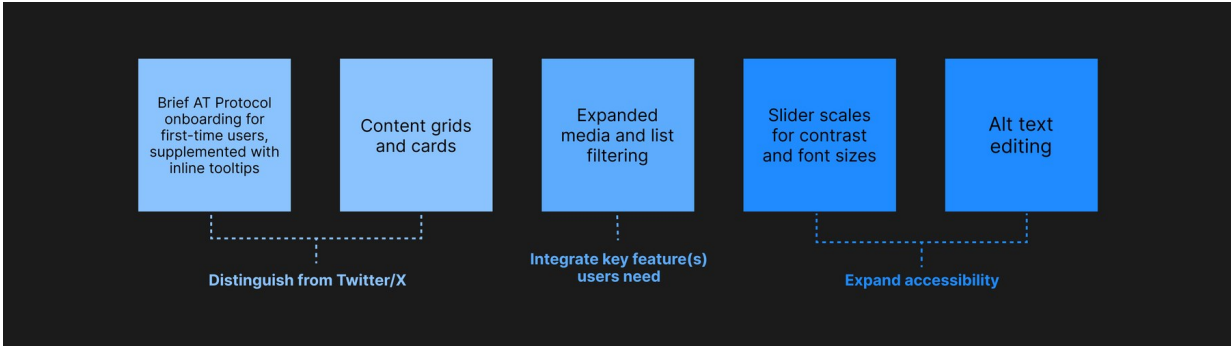


Figure 8. Final feature set carried into design.

4. Design

DESIGN AND PROTOTYPE RESULTS

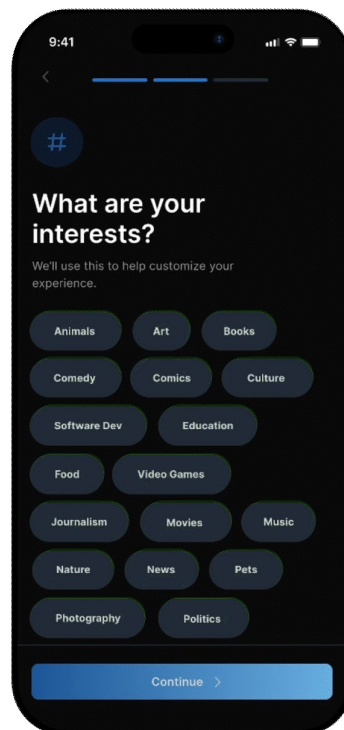
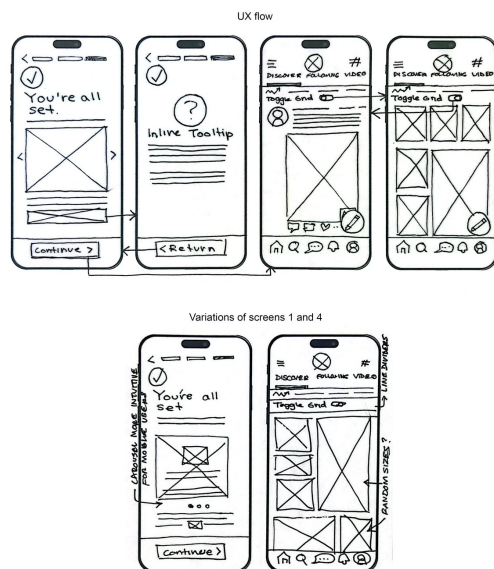
Transforming paper wireframes into high-fidelity prototypes

With the core features decided, I sketched paper wireframes and tested them quickly with a group of six participants. Their feedback fed directly into rapid iteration in Figma. Because Bluesky already has a coherent design system, these updates could be built efficiently, which kept the project on schedule within the one-week constraint.

Since the vast majority of Bluesky users access the app on handheld devices, I adopted a mobile-first approach and progressively scaled the designs upward for tablet screen sizes rather than designing for desktop and shrinking down.

REDESIGN, PART 1

Defining Bluesky: educating users and providing a new display option



Paper wireframe

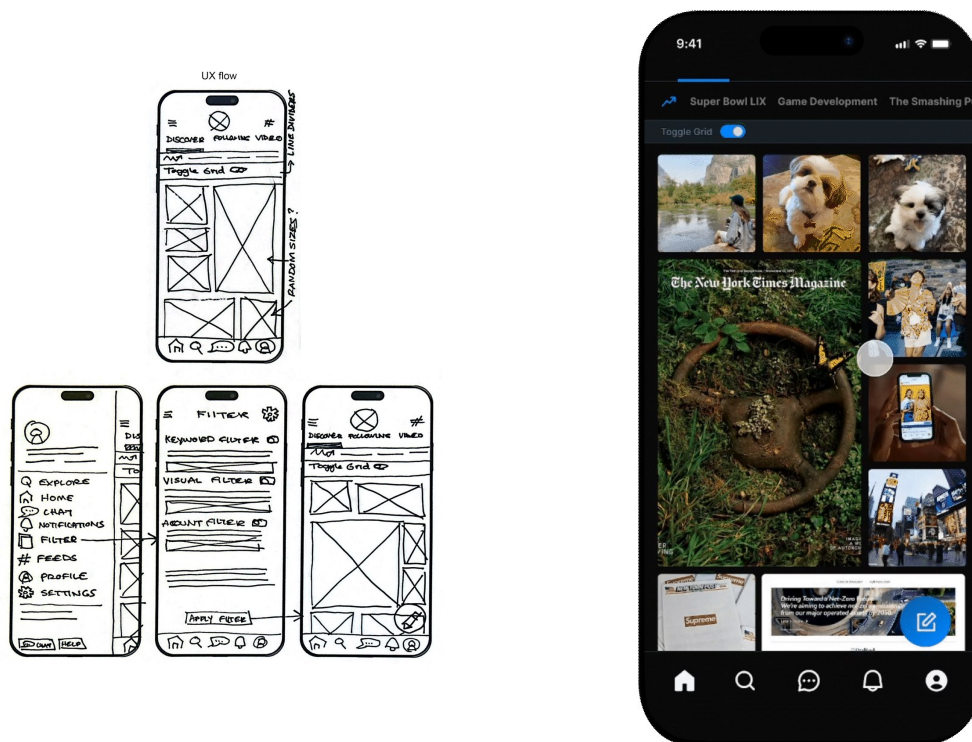
Final prototype

Figure 9. AT Protocol onboarding and the new media grid view, from paper wireframe to final prototype.

Approach. To help Bluesky stand apart from Twitter/X, I added AT Protocol educational tools alongside a new media grid view. Users repeatedly said they did not understand what made Bluesky different, so this redesign briefly onboards new users with AT Protocol concepts and provides inline tooltips for those who want to go deeper. The grid view offers a fresh way to explore content while preserving the familiar timeline for anyone who prefers it.

REDESIGN, PART 2

Applying filters to media, enabled by Bluesky's architecture



Paper wireframe

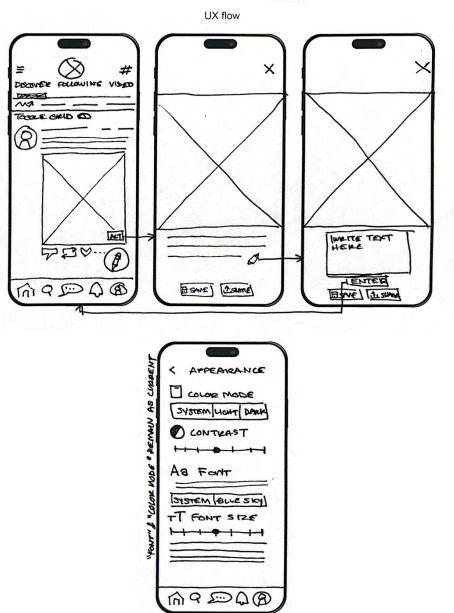
Final prototype

Figure 10. Algorithmic feed filters: text keywords, visual keywords, and account topics.

Approach. Research indicates that many people left Twitter/X when it breached their digital autonomy, essentially forcing them to consume content outside of their personal algorithm. That moment sparked wide discussion about transparency and customization as essential features of social media, not nice-to-haves. Building on Bluesky's community-controlled appeal, this redesign lets users tailor their experience by toggling on a range of algorithmic filters. In this iteration, users can set text and visual keywords and select account topics to fine-tune what reaches their feed.

REDESIGN, PART 3

Expanding and improving accessibility through alt text and appearance



Paper wireframe



Final prototype

Figure 11. Editable alt text and continuous contrast and font-size sliders.

Approach. When it comes to making everyone feel welcome on a new platform, the research kept pointing to visual customization, and especially to features that serve users with visual impairments. The redesign takes a two-pronged approach: first, letting users add or edit alt text that is missing or incorrect; and second, replacing preset appearance options with sliders for contrast and font size.

The first feature is easy to overlook, and larger platforms do overlook it, but it was cited again and again in Bluesky's Reddit threads as essential. Giving users the ability to correct or add alt text significantly broadens access to media content, because it no longer depends on every poster remembering to write it. The sliders, meanwhile, let users fine-tune their viewing experience instead of choosing the least-bad of three presets.

5. Reflection

FINAL SCREENS AND COMPONENTS

Talking to users and gathering insights

After incorporating the features described above, I re-engaged a select group of participants from the initial paper wireframe testing, this time to gather feedback on the high-fidelity digital prototypes. Testing with the same people let me check whether the concerns they raised at the paper stage had actually been resolved rather than just moved.

Overall, users responded positively to the improvements in functionality and accessibility, especially given the project's constraints. Several described the additional screens as "intuitive" and "necessary," and a few offered suggestions for future iterations, which I take as the most encouraging sign of all: people only suggest improvements to things they intend to keep using.

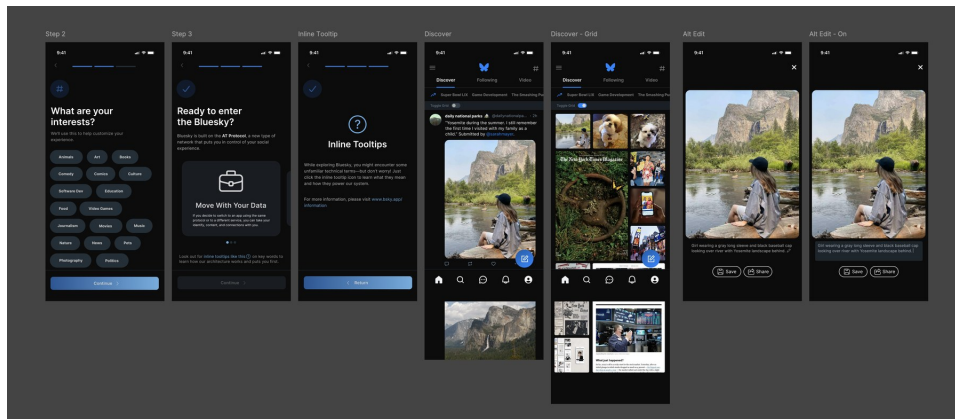


Figure 12. Final screens: onboarding, grid view, and filter flows.

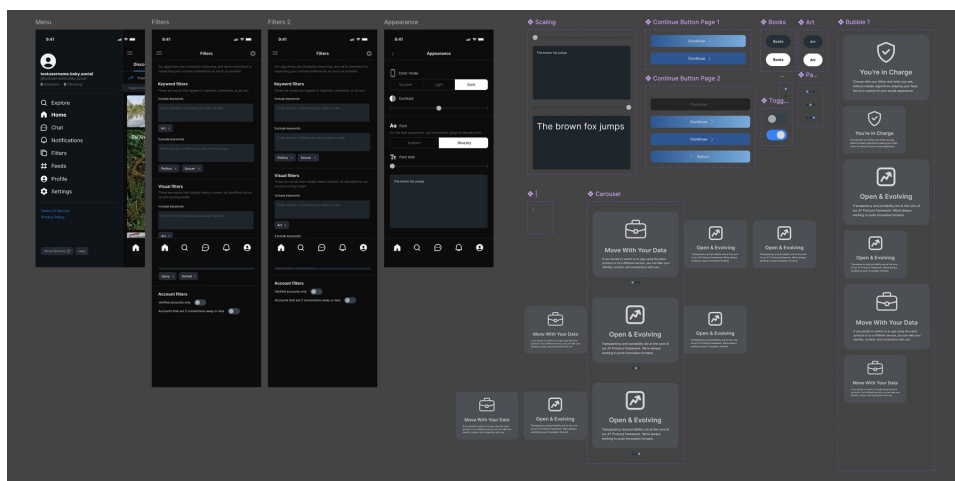


Figure 13. Final screens: accessibility settings and alt text editing. Some secondary screens and components are omitted for brevity.

LIMITATIONS

What a one-week, one-person sprint can and cannot claim

I want to be clear about scope. The research is secondary: it draws on what users chose to say in public, which over-represents the frustrated and the articulate. Six participants is enough to catch obvious usability problems but not to make quantitative claims, and none of the six had a visual impairment, which means the accessibility features were evaluated by proxy. A next iteration would recruit screen-reader and magnifier users directly, test on real devices at real text sizes, and measure whether the onboarding actually changes what people can explain about the AT Protocol afterward.

REFLECTION AND TAKEAWAYS

Two things this project taught me

1. Designing to improve, not to fatigue

Competing platforms offer a wide array of accessibility features, and it is tempting to include them all. But one thing the research made clear is that too many options overwhelm. I let research drive prioritization and kept the feature set focused and purposeful. The discipline was not in coming up with ideas; it was in leaving most of them on the board.

2. Accessibility and the status quo

Huge platforms like Reddit and Twitter/X do not offer alt text editing, so why should I? That question sat with me for a while. How can platforms of that size overlook such a simple feature, one that would vastly expand media access for so many people? The honest answer is that today's accessibility standards are far behind where they should be. Despite hundreds, if not thousands, of users voicing their desire for this feature, major platforms seem to believe they have already met an acceptable threshold. In UX, one thing has always proven true: the users always have the answers. The job is to listen to them even when the industry has decided not to.

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